



Inspiring Excellence

POL101: Introduction to Political Science

Team Script

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Team-03
Section 20
Summer 2026

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Afnan: Hello everyone, and welcome to this wonderful podcast, where we will talk about Uruguay, Ghana, Singapore, and Tunisia to explain variation in democratic accountability, political competition, development, and state power. We will use Schmitter & Karl, Siegle, Weinstein, Halperin, Eva Bellin's analysis of authoritarianism, and Jan-Werner Müller as evidence from our reading materials. Currently, the FIW scores of Uruguay, Ghana, Singapore, and Tunisia are 97, 80, 48, and 42, respectively (Freedom House, 2026). Our lineups are as follows: Mashrafi – Uruguay, Tassuba – Singapore, Marian – Tunisia, Arsalan – Ghana. My name is Afnan, and I will be the Team Analyst for this podcast.

But as we know, a key problem is that economic development and state capacity fail to account for democratic success, so what is it? Looking at Uruguay, one can see how they were able to sustain a stable democracy through their political institutions and competition, and Ghana, despite some economic issues, has some meaningful democratic competition. That only reflects the fact that, even when a nation is suffering economically, it can have meaningful democratic competition. Singapore, on the other hand, is a highly developed and capable state, having less democratic accountability and less political competition. Finally, Tunisia demonstrates that while Tunisia may make democratic advances, it can go backwards when the institutional framework is weakened and executive authority is increased.

So without further ado, let's dig deeper into this spectrum of democracy and state power. Let's start with Uruguay first. In your opinion, what does your country represent in the aspect of democracy and political system?

Mashrafi: Thanks, Afnan. So Uruguay is the one that makes a strong case for democracy among the four countries. It has an institutionalized political mechanism that illustrates the value of competition and accountability. They argue that the real key to democracy is a process; democracy is not about results but about a certain procedure: that rulers should be held accountable by citizens, not only through voting but also through contestation by organized groups, and that there should be competition and cooperation among elected representatives. (Schmitter & Karl 1991). They also take care to emphasize that liberal democracy enriches that minimum.

Afnan: That is a great insight. My question for you is, does Uruguay reach the more liberal-democratic bar as well as the procedural minimum? What's Uruguay's FIW breakdown?

Mashrafi: Yeah, sure. So the last five years, Uruguay has performed very strongly. Its FIW scores were 97/100 in 2022 and 96 in 2023 and remained the same till 2026 (Freedom House, 2026). Maps almost exactly onto their distinction between "electoral democracy" and "liberal democracy." Uruguay clears both, but the civil liberties dents are exactly the kind of thing Schmitter & Karl would flag as where a democracy can be procedurally sound but imperfectly liberal.

The strength of Uruguay's democracy is not a byproduct of elections. Elections are meaningful because they allow for the contestation of political parties, citizens' engagement in elections, and the limitation of government power through democratic institutions.

Afnan: But why is it important? What do you think, Mashrafi?

Mashrafi: This is relevant to the fact that Schmitter and Karl prescribe against defining democracy solely in terms of elections (Schmitter & Karl, 1991). A nation can conduct elections but have restricted competition or exclude citizens from having a meaningful impact on political decisions.

Afnan: So what do you say? Does Uruguay represent a strong democracy?

Mashrafi: Yes, Uruguay is a system that has a broader system of accountability that supports democratic procedures. No one man or political body has absolute power. Rather, competition and institutional limitations will create institutional mechanisms by which leaders can be made accountable.

Afnan: Very nicely put. Now let's shift our focus to Tunisia. I heard Tunisia experienced democratic backsliding. Could you guide me on how this happened?

Marian: Absolutely, you're correct. Tunisia was the first country in the Arab world to follow the Arab Spring in 2011 and thus set an example for democratic transition in the region (Bellin, 2012). The collapse of the authoritarian regime opened space for political engagement, competitive elections, and institutional changes. To develop a more progressive political system, Tunisia adopted a constitution in 2014. Eva Bellin's formulation on the apparatus helps us understand the collapse of Tunisia's authoritarian regime in 2011.

Afnan: Oh, is that so? Could you kindly elaborate on this topic? What can we take from Bellin's teaching regarding this?

Marian: Bellin (2012) suggests that repression is critical to a regime's survival and that the capacity and willingness of coercive institutions of the state are key determinants of such repression. In Tunisia, the military decided not to fire at the protesters. This was an important one to make simply because, Bellin (2012) explains, when the coercive apparatus is not prepared to support the regime with force, an authoritarian ruler will lose the capacity to stay in power. So Tunisia provides an example to us of how, when a society is mobilized and the military is not willing to crush it, authoritarianism can fall.

Afnan: I see. But looking at Tunisia, we saw that the collapse of a regime doesn't guarantee a democracy. Furthermore, what are the last five years' FIW scores of Tunisia?

Marian: The FIW score in 2022 was 56/100; then in 2023, it was 51; and in 2024 and 2025, it was 44, and in 2026, the score is 40 out of 100 (Freedom House, 2026).

Afnan: Could you please add more context to it?

Marian: In July 2021, President Kaïs Saïed fired the minister, dissolved and suspended parliament, and added to the centralisation of political power in his office. Later put in place a

constitution that empowered the president. (Freedom House, 2025). This is in contrast to Tunisia's previous transition from democracy to executive centralization and re-authoritarianism.

Afnan: As long as elections still happen, but there isn't really much political competition, is it still fully democratic?

Marian: According to Schmitter and Karl (1991), the answer is no. Democracy depends on more than just voting. The people of the country need to participate and express their opinion as well as hold the leaders accountable. Thus, it can be observed that institutions established in the context of a democratic transition can be weakened from within. But Tunisia is not a story of the downfall of an authoritarian regime. It's about the fall and what comes after it. Why it's much harder to build democratic institutions than to remove the authoritarian leader.

Afnan: Excellent take on Tunisia. Now, shifting to Singapore. Tassuba, can you please talk a bit about your country? Where does your country stand with respect to democracy and political stance?

Tassuba: Thank you, Afnan. So Singapore is an important example in our comparison. Singapore is a well-developed state with a strong economy. Since 1959, though, the political system has been run by the People's Action Party (PAP). Singapore has a multiparty system and regular elections, but its political and legal system hinders the development of opposition parties and restricts political freedoms.

Afnan: What about the FIW score? Could you explain this further?

Tassuba: Yeah sure. Freedom House classifies Singapore as “Partly Free” and gives it a score of 48 out of 100, reflecting limitations on political competition and certain civil liberties. In 2022, the score was 47, and from 2023 to 2026, it remained 48 out of 100 (Freedom House, 2026).

Afnan: I see. Could you explain what Singapore’s development shows us about the relationship between democracy and economic development?

Tassuba: Yes, Singapore plays an important role in the discussion on development and democracy. Siegle, Weinstein, and Halperin (2004) challenge the idea that democratic nations need to give up democracy or resort to authoritarianism in order to develop economically. Singapore is regarded as a success story of a strong and dominant government. But one success does not indicate the universal need for limited political competition to promote development. Accountability, transparency, and responsiveness to citizens are also tools that can help promote development in democracies (Siegle, Weinstein, & Halperin, 2004).

Mashrafi: I think here we can see the important comparison with Uruguay. Both Singapore and Uruguay have capable institutions. But according to my analysis, Uruguay provides more great opportunities for political competition and changes in political power than Singapore.

Tassuba: Exactly, this has led to effective administration and long-term economic development in Singapore due to its strong state capacity. This comparison demonstrates, however, that the state and democracy are not synonymous. There is no contradiction between having a strong state, high economic development, and low political competition.

Therefore, economic development and robust state power are no guarantee of democratic accountability, which supports our argument. The key components of democracy, such as meaningful political competition and accountability, remain essential (Schmitter & Karl, 1991).

Afnan: So, I think Singapore is mainly our strongest example, which highlights development, state power, political competition, and, lastly, democratic accountability. And these four things do not move together.

Tassuba: Yeah, you are right, Afnan. Also, I can say Singapore is stronger than Ghana.

Afnan: Thank you, Tassuba. As you have mentioned Ghana, now coming to the last country of today's session, the Republic of Ghana, Arsalan, please share your findings.

Arsalan: Thank you, Afnan. Firstly, I want to say it was really delightful to hear about other countries. Now, coming to Ghana. Before starting, what is the first thing that comes to your mind when you hear Ghana?

Mashrafi: Political instability.

Marian: Huge gap between rich and poor.

Tassuba: Corruption.

Afnan: Poor infrastructure.

Arsalan: Yes, you guys are correct. The first thing that came to my mind was broken roads, broken vehicles, and no safety standards. They were one of the reasons why I chose Ghana in the first place. But when I dug deeper into Ghana's political situation, my view on Ghana's political landscape totally changed.

Afnan: Really? Could you please elaborate on it?

Arsalan: Well, when I started looking at the Freedom in the World score of Ghana, I observed a pattern: Ghana had a constant score of 80 for the past 5 years, political rights at 35/40, and civil rights at 45/60. The reason for this constant score is the smooth and peaceful power transfer between the two parties: the National Democratic Congress (NDC) and National Patriotic Party (NPP). The first thing that came to my mind was Jan-Werner Müller's populism theory.

Afnan: Sorry for interrupting you, Arsalan. A constant score is really impressive; can you tell us how long the score has been constant?

Arsalan: The score has been constant since 2022. They had a score of 82 previously, but it dropped due to using weapons on protestors and raiding the country's first LGBTQ+ community center.

Afnan: Thank you; please continue with Muller's theory that you mentioned previously.

Arsalan: So Müller (2016) suggests that the danger of democracy is anti-pluralism: leaders who claim that they are the only ones representing the people and that the opponent is illegitimate. For this theory, Ghana comes out to be an outlier. Now, digging deeper into the score of political rights, which is 35/40. Ghana has only 2 major political parties. While smaller parties tried to join elections, they were deregistered for failing requirements, and high filing fees make it harder for smaller parties to join. Ghana has been an interesting country to do research on, and maybe digging more will change my view further.

Afnan: Certainly, you're right on that. Before we close, there is one limitation that I have analysed while making this comparison between the four countries. We have all talked only about institutional design and political competition as the main drivers of these outcomes. We need to keep in mind other factors such as colonial legacy, population size, geography, and others that shaped these trajectories to be how they are right now. If we compare Singapore and Uruguay, they differ in size as well as historical background. This divergent path may reflect why it's not only institutional choices alone. Furthermore, comparing only four countries is too bold a basis for a global claim. Like Bellin's bounded generalization, our comparison is case-specific and illustrative, not a universal prediction (Bellin, 2012).

Well, that's all for today. Thank you for listening to our podcast. We hope you have a wonderful day. Take care and goodbye.

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Student's Name	Country or role	Main contribution
Afnan Mohammad Hafiz	Team Representative	Connected the conversation, made questions relevant to the topic and speaker, included a comparative analysis and limitations
Ahmed Arsalan Nafis	Ghana lead	Pointed out Muller's theory, added in-text citation
Tassuba Ahmed	Singapore lead	Pointed out Siegle, Weinstein, & Halperin, analysed the FIW Scores
Marian Baroi	Tunisia lead	Pointed out Bellin's theory; added a practical story for context
Mashrafi Islam Alif	Uruguay lead	Pointed out Schmitter & Karl's theory